

Calligraphy inscribed above an arch inside the Taj

Another part of the building that naturally stands out is the dome itself, an important element of Persian architecture (though not widely used in pre-Islamic India)[34]. The greatest surviving dome from Ancient Europe is the one above the Pantheon in Rome, which has a diameter of 142 feet (both around and from floor to ceiling) and was completed in 123 A.D.[35]. Somewhat smaller is the dome of the Hagia Sophia Church/Mosque in Byzantium/Istanbul, with a diameter of 102 feet and completed in 537 AD[36]. The Taj dome is a bit different than these because it is in an "onion" style, which is shared between Persian, Mughal and Eastern Orthodox architecture, and unlike the domes of the Hagia Sophia and the Pantheon, it is not a perfect circle but instead reaches to a point. In total, it reaches up to 144 feet, slightly exceeding that of the Pantheon. However, like Christopher Wren's dome in St. Paul's Cathedral, the Taj's interior actually has a false domed ceiling roughly halfway up the interior. This is meant to maintain a sense of human scale in the interior and allow for decorations to be visible from the floor, all while still maintaining the grand exterior scale of the structure[37].